

semantic information available to machines. Examples of semantic web community-type portals at present are the academic community portals Esperanto and OntoWeb. Commercial-type community portals include Empolis K42 and Mondeca ITM. The potential of using Semantic Web technologies amongst these communities could improve information processing and sharing amongst the members [1].

1.2 Social and Business Social networking sites

This section of the paper will discuss 10 popular business and social networking sites that have appeared recently on the Internet. The list provides an overview of the sites that have a steadily increasing and growing number of members creating virtual communities online. Members join the various communities and create a user profile in the site and can connect to one another within the community.

Ecademy (www.ecademy.com)

Ecademy is a business networking site built up of a network of trusted business connections for people to share contacts and business opportunities. It is free to join, however membership can be upgraded to power networker for 14 a month. It has a list of Ecademy clubs that its members can join, as well as listings of meetings and when they will be taking place. It also contains a list of networking regions globally for arranging meetings and events offline.

Friendster (www.friendster.com)

Friendster, established in March 2003, has already attracted millions of members following many articles in popular computing magazines and newspapers and online “buzz”. Friendster is primarily a site for social connections: for dating through one’s own friends and their friends; for making new friends; and for helping friends to meet other new people. A member’s photo and profile are only shown to people in their personal network, and messages can only be sent and received from those with a mutual network of friends. Friendster is currently in its beta phase, during which membership is free, but after the trial some subscription features are to be added.